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Generating and testing flying focus laser pulses with Lasy for PIconGPU simulations

— A Bachelors Defense —

Edgar Marquardt

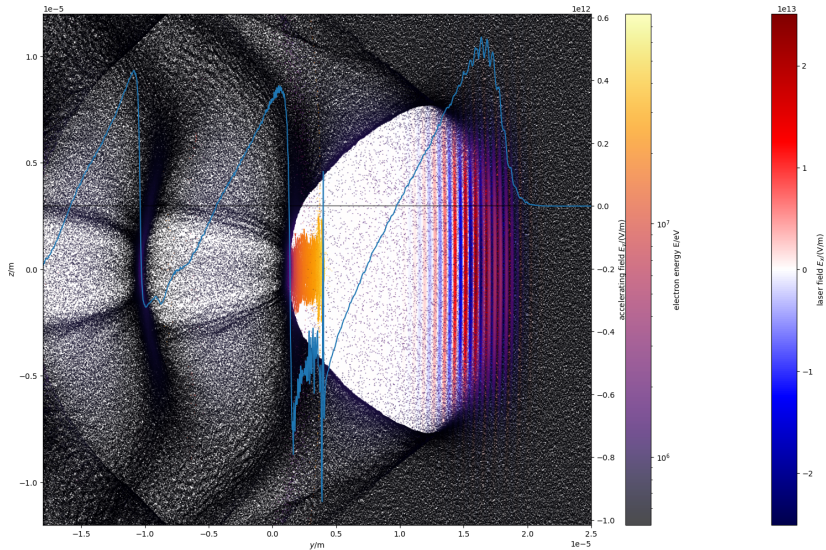
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19.02.2026



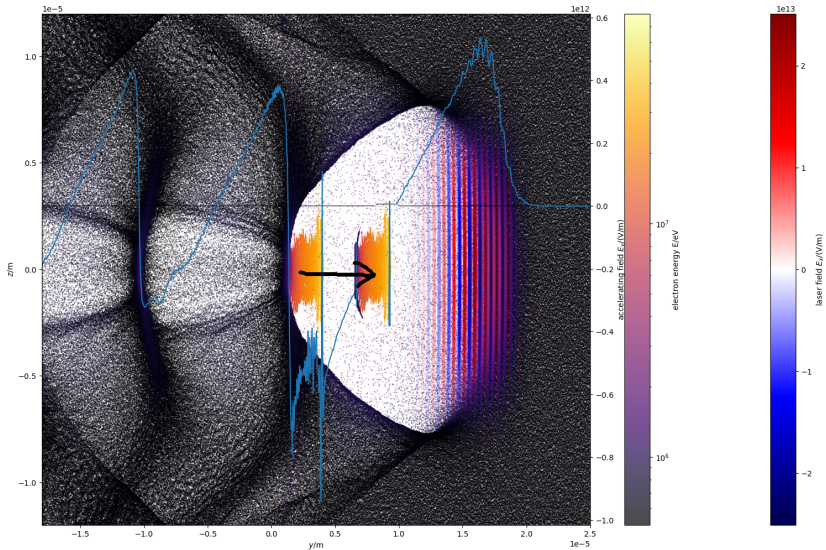
1 Dephasingless Laser WakeField Acceleration (DLWFA)

Laser WakeField Acceleration (LWFA)



Electric field and electrons in an LWFA (see [1]) simulation.

The problem of dephasing



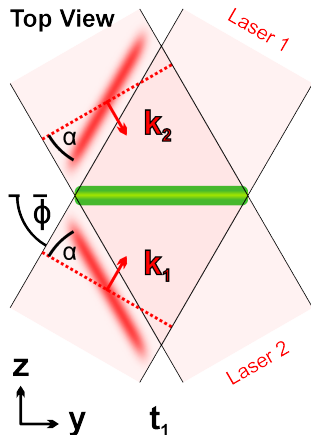
Dephasing in LWFA. Schematic.

Flying focus lasers – solving the problem of dephasing

1. TWEAC

- **T**raveling-**W**ave **E**lectron **A**ccelerator
- Developed by Debus et al [2]
- Uses two laser pulses with tilted pulse fronts
- The tilt controls the velocity of the overlapping region

Image: TWEAC setup using two laser pulses. Image taken from Debus [3]

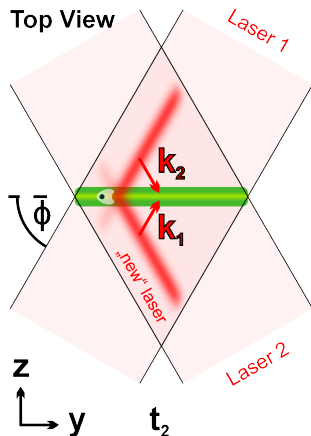


Flying focus lasers – solving the problem of dephasing

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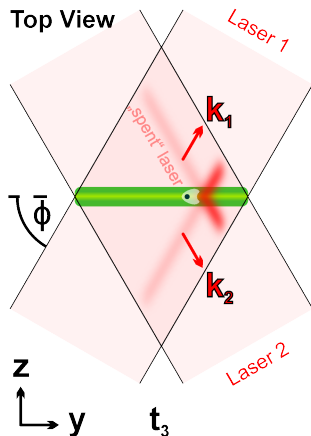


Flying focus lasers – solving the problem of dephasing

1. TWEAC

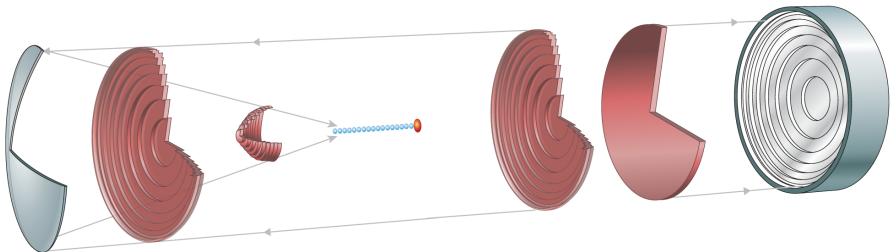
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Flying focus lasers – solving the Problem of dephasing

2. Axiparabola laser



The flying focus setup of Palastro et al [4]. Two optical elements: The Axiparabola (left) and the Radial Group Delay echelon (RGD) (right). Image taken from Palastro et al [4].

Flying focus lasers – solving the Problem of dephasing

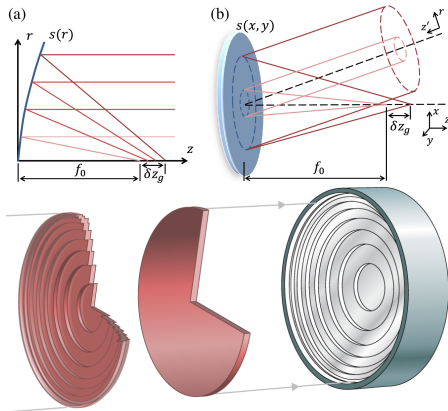
2. Axiparabola laser

■ Axiparabola [5]:

- Near-parabolic mirror
- Focuses light onto a line – the focus region
- Light at radius r is focused at $f(r) = f_0 + \delta \left(\frac{r}{R} \right)^2$

■ Radial Group Delay echelon (RGD) [6][4]:

- Stepped concentric mirror rings
- Shape follows some function $\tau_D(r)$
- controls the timing of the axiparabola focus



Images: Top: Axiparabola functionality. Image taken from Smartsev et al [5]. Bottom: RGD functionality. Image taken from Palastro et al [4].



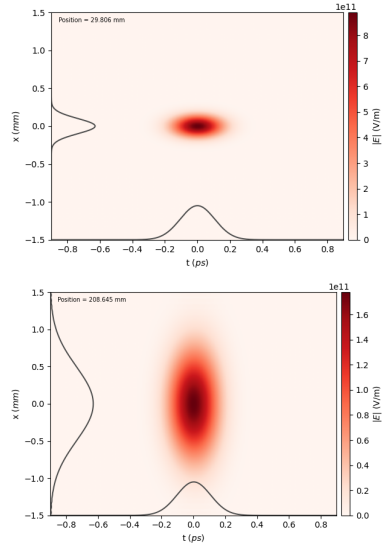
2 Flying focus lasers in Lasy and PIConGPU

Lasy

A python library

- A python library for simulating Laser pulses in a vacuum [7]
- Uses complex envelope of the laser field
- Uses angular spectrum propagation
- Can use cylindrical coordinates for memory and CPU time efficiency
- Offers a range of optical elements

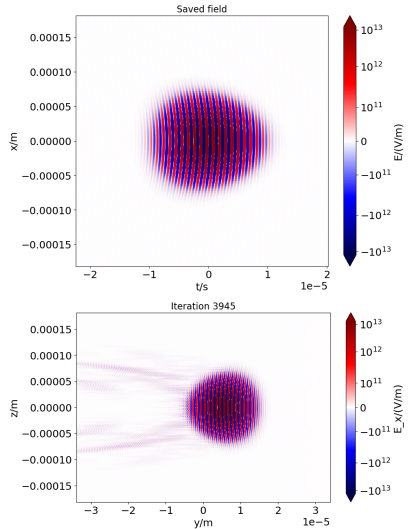
Images: Example of a Gaussian pulse being propagated by Lasy. Top: Generated at the focus. Bottom: $6 z_R$ after the focus.



Importing to PIConGPU

- New module `full_field`
- Generates full electric field and saves it using `openPMD-api`
- `incidentField` method
`FromOpenPMDPulse` (see Dietrich [8]) imports the field into PIConGPU

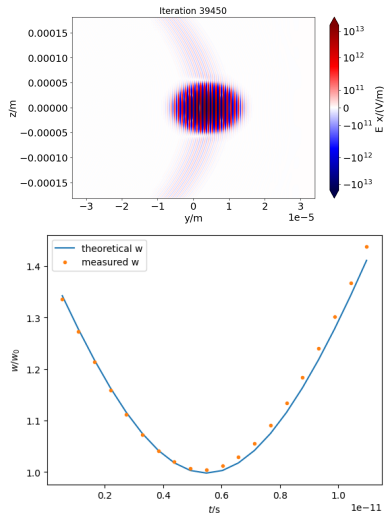
Images: Top: Electric field of a Gaussian laser pulse, $1z_R$ before the focus, as saved to the file. Bottom: That same electric field entering the simulation window of a PIConGPU simulation.



Testing the method

- Test with Gaussian laser pulse and parabolic mirror
- Some artifacts are visible
 - Problem of the incidentField method
 - See [9]
- Test successful

Images: Top: Electric field of the Gaussian laser pulse at the focus according to the PIconGPU simulation. Bottom: The beam waist w of the pulse over time, compared to theory.



Implementing the flying focus

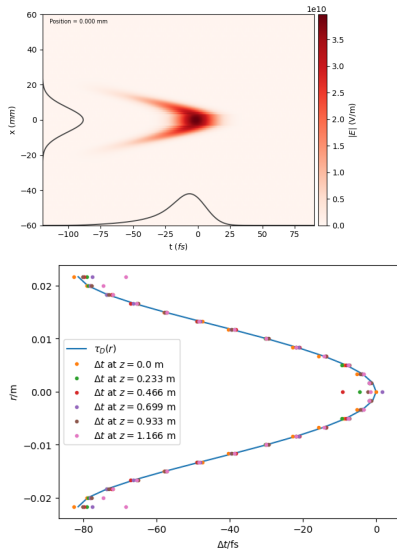
1. The radial group delay echelon (RGD)

- Implemented from scratch as Lasy optical element
- Following the description by Ambat et al [6]
- Shapes the pulse temporally without focusing or defocusing
- Can generate any radially symmetric shape of delay $\tau_D(r)$

Images: A Gaussian pulse after interacting with the RGD.

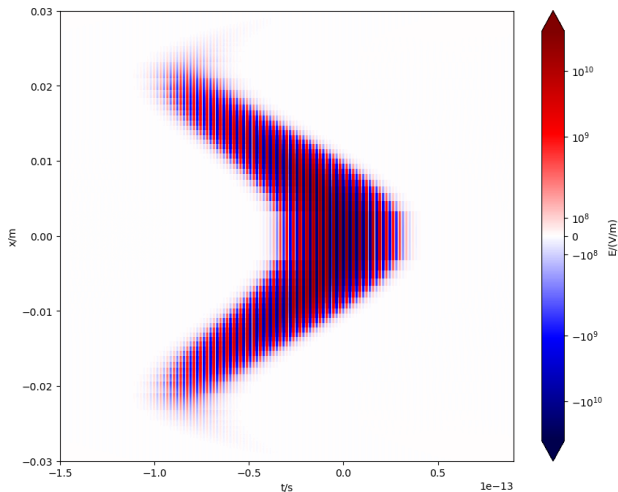
Top: Field envelope. Bottom: Test results. Even after long distances the shape still holds. For comparison:

$z_R \approx 290$ m



Implementing the flying focus

1. The radial group delay echelon (RGD)



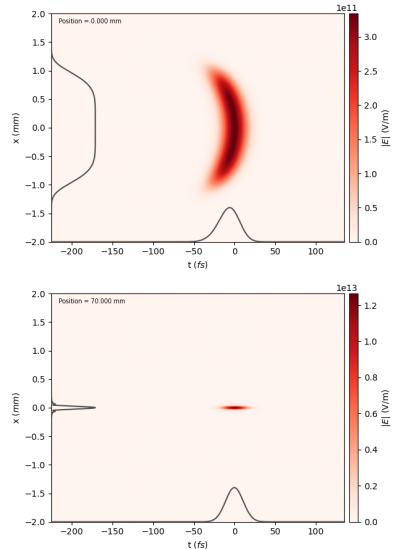
The electric field of the laser after interacting with the RGD.

Implementing the flying focus

2. The axiparabola

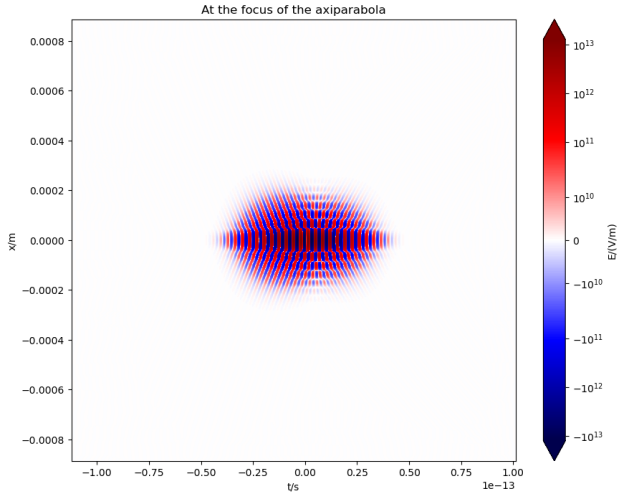
- Included in Lasy
- Following Smartsev et al [5]
- Focusing laser pulse in the focus region
- Also implemented an axiparabola following Ambat et al [6]
 - Very small differences

Images: A super-Gaussian laser pulse after reflecting off the axiparabola. Top: In the near field. Bottom: In the far field at the beginning of the focus region.



Implementing the flying focus

2. The axiparabola



The electric field of the laser at the beginning of the focus region of the axiparabola.

Implementing the flying focus

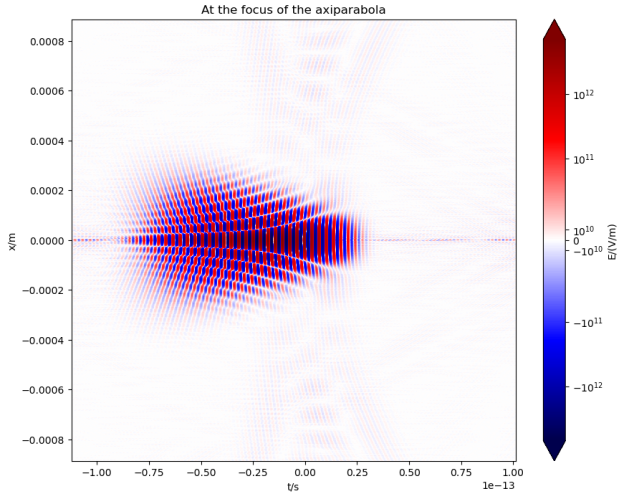
The complete setup

The simulation had the following steps:

- 1 Initialising the laser pulse with its pulse profile
- 2 Applying the RGD to the laser
- 3 Applying the axiparabola to the laser
- 4 Propagating the laser to the focus region
 - At this point the laser field can be saved to file
 - The next steps can happen in Lasy or PIConGPU
- 5 Measuring the relative focus position $t_{focus} - f_0/c$ or $z_{focus} - t \cdot c$ and the beam waist w
- 6 Propagating the laser some distance through the focus region
- 7 Repeating steps 5 and 6 until the end of the focus region is reached

Implementing the flying focus

The complete setup



The electric field of the laser at the beginning of the focus region of the complete setup.



3 Verifying the flying focus

Verifying the flying focus

The measurement

- Relative focus position $t_{focus} - f_0/c$ (Lasy) or $z_{focus} - t \cdot c$ (PIConGPU):
 - A central line-out is taken from the field energy, already in relative coordinates
 - Then $t_{focus} - f_0/c$ or $z_{focus} - t \cdot c$ is calculated as the expected value of the resulting distribution
- Beam waist w :
 - The field energy is longitudinally and azimuthally summed
 - Then w is calculated from the statistical standard deviation of the resulting distribution

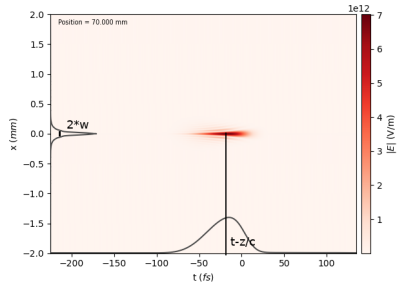


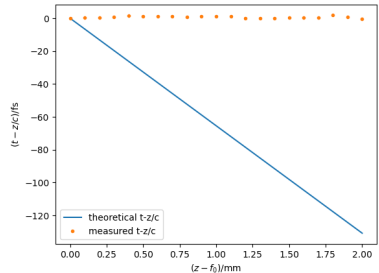
Image: An example of where the measurements can be found in the plots.

Verifying the flying focus

First results

- Simulation in Lasy
 - Result: The flying focus effect cannot be seen
- Test failed

Image: Comparing relative focus position measurements $t_{focus} - z/c$ from a Lasy simulation to the expected evolution.





4 What went wrong?

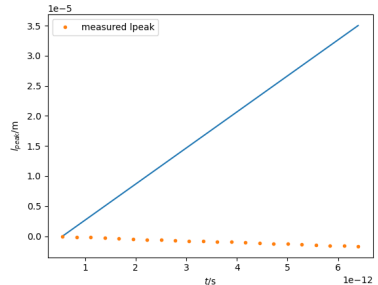
What went wrong?

The same simulation in PIConGPU

- Simulation in Easy to the focus region, from there in PIConGPU
 - Result: The flying focus effect cannot be seen here either
- Test also failed

Image: Comparing relative focus position measurements

$z_{focus} - t \cdot c$ from a PIConGPU simulation to the expected evolution.



What went wrong?

Checking the shapes of the optical elements

- Multiple differential equations for the shape of the RGD $\tau_D(r)$
 - All result in very similar shapes
- Multiple equations for the shape of the axiparabola $s_f(r)$
 - All follow from the same differential equation (and solve it)
 - All are very similar shapes

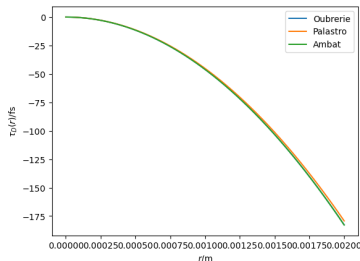


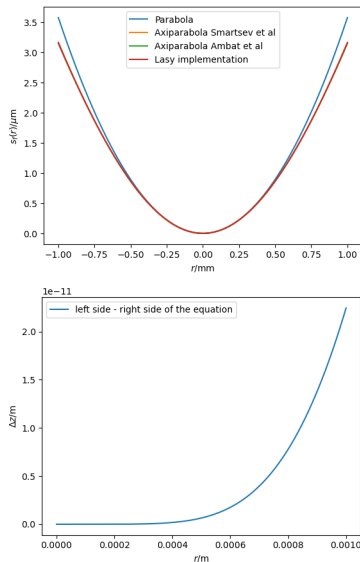
Image: The delay the RGD should achieve according to different sources. The shape of the RGD is similar to this, just stepped in $\lambda_0/2$ steps. Relative differences $\approx 1/50$.

What went wrong?

Checking the shapes of the optical elements

- Multiple differential equations for the shape of the RGD $\tau_D(r)$
 - All result in very similar shapes
- Multiple equations for the shape of the axiparabola $s_f(r)$
 - All follow from the same differential equation (and solve it)
 - All are very similar shapes

Images: Top: The shape of the axiparabola according to different sources. Relative differences $\approx 10^{-2}$. Bottom: The difference between the two sides of the differential equation the axiparabola is derived from.



What went wrong?

Testing all the used modules

- Some successful tests were already shown:
 - A test of Lasy itself
 - A test of the methods to import Lasy pulses into PIconGPU
 - Tests of the RGD

→ These modules work as intended

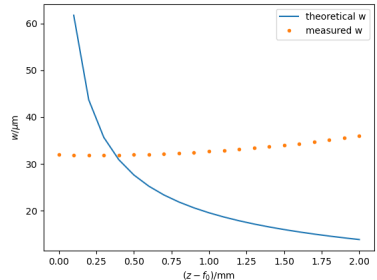
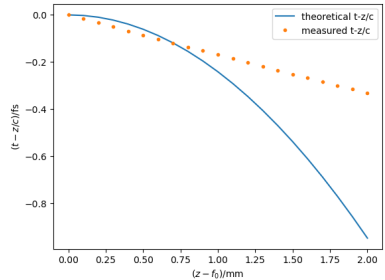
- The field plots corroborate the measured values

What went wrong?

Testing the axiparabola alone

- With only the axiparabola differences appear already
 - Here must be the problem
- Using the axiparabola described by Ambat et al [6] gives similar results
- Contacted the Lasy developers to no avail (so far)

Images: Comparing measurements from a Lasy simulation with theoretical values using Ambat et al [6]. Top: Arrival time $t - z/c$. Bottom: Beam waist w .



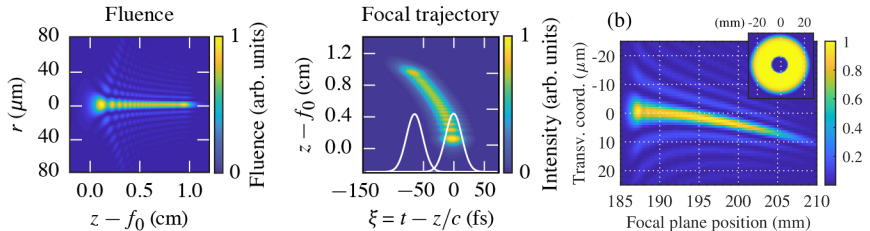


5 Summary and Outlook

Summary

These tests were done:

- All the code was tested with Gaussian laser pulses
 - The shapes of the optical elements were compared to different sources
 - The flying focus pulse was simulated and compared in Lasy and PIconGPU
 - Simulations with just the axiparabola already show differences between theory and measurement
- The Lasy developers were contacted



Simulation results from other papers using only the axiparabola, showing it worked for them without Lasy.

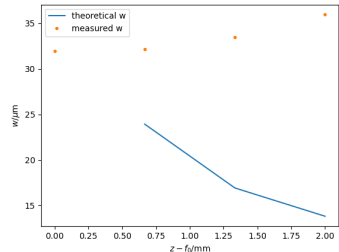
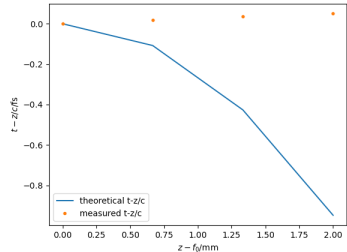
Left (Fluence and Focal trajectory): Ambat et al [6]. Right (b): Smartsev et al [5]

Further tests after writing

Using different propagation methods

- Propagation methods tried:
 - Lasy's own angular spectrum propagator
 - Can only handle small numbers of points, useless for us
 - Fresnel chirp-z transform propagator
 - Slow, but can handle larger numbers of points
 - Very similar results to previous tests
- So far, no test successfully showed the flying focus effect

Images: Comparing measurements from a Lasy simulation, using Fresnel chirp-z transform propagation, with theoretical values using Ambat et al [6]. Top: Arrival time $t - z/c$. Bottom: Beam waist w .



- Lazy lasers available in PIconGPU
- LWFA with new laser setups possible
- Specific problems with the axiparabola still need resolving
- Some tests conducted after writing the bachelors thesis, did not help:
 - Trying different propagation methods
 - Initialising the pulse with other pulse profiles (Gaussian, Super-Gaussian, Rect)
 - Using Cartesian coordinates on nodes with 1.5 TB memory

(*) There's more to explore here.

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Laser electron-accelerator.
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J. P. Palastro, J. L. Shaw, P. Franke, D. Ramsey, T. T. Simpson, and D. H. Froula.
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References (II)



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Axiparabola: a long-focal-depth, high-resolution mirror for broadband high-intensity lasers.

Optics Letters, 44, 2019.



M. V. Ambat, J. L. Shaw, J. J. Pigeon, K. G. Miller, T. T. Simpson, D. H. Froula, and J. P. Palastro.

Programmable-trajectory ultrafast flying focus pulses.

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<https://lasydoc.readthedocs.io/en/latest>.

Accessed october 2025.



Fabia Dietrich.

Implementation and validation of a method for using experimentally measured laser profiles in laser-plasma simulations with picongpu.

Master's thesis, HZDR, TU Dresden, 2024.

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Klaus Steiniger.

Issue 5269 todo in laser refactoring.

<https://github.com/ComputationalRadiationPhysics/picongpu/issues/5269>.

Accessed october 2025.



Remaining Possible reasons for failure

- The Axiparabola
 - The shape could still be wrong
- The Propagation
 - Possibly the Lasy propagation gives incorrect/incomplete results
- The Findings in the other papers
 - Maybe the Axiparabola does not work at all
 - Maybe it works in a different manner
- The chosen parameters might not fulfill some important approximation condition